Become You

Say "I am," then live it.



TEXT BY
Lily

01 Business restructuring coach for founder-led brands

02 Producer & translator of 20+ bestsellers

03 Co-founder, Play and Prosper

I was sitting in a stranger's home: my first visit, after nearly four hours on the road.

She asked me to say one sentence out loud.

I said it. In that moment I felt so light, so glad, as if I had grown taller.

That year, I was at my lowest.

01

I had lost my soul

Before that, I spent five years working nine to five at a semiconductor company. Each time I changed jobs my pay doubled, and I went from working for others to working for myself, all the way up to the ceiling above my head.

It sounds good. But every day I did the same thing: sat at the computer, the screen lit, my heart gone.

One day I was suddenly afraid. Five years from now, will I still be sitting in this chair, doing the same work? I could see that future me, and she was not who I wanted to be. I couldn't breathe: no, I have to change. But I didn't know how.

It wasn't only the chair I couldn't sit still in. In those years I felt empty inside. I never felt I was worth much; I went looking for love outside myself and didn't find it. At my desk I was like someone who had lost her soul. Even being alive didn't seem to mean much. The blue sky outside looked gray to me.

Deeper down, I had locked myself inside three “I don’t want”s. I didn’t want to be a “strong woman”: every one I had met was harder than the last. I didn’t want to be rich: the rich people I had seen cheated on their spouses or used money to push others around, and not one of them was happy. Yet in spiritual classes I met people who had cultivated themselves beautifully and were dirt poor, and I didn’t want that either.

I was gentle, soft and small, and that is how I kept the strong women, the rich and the poor seekers all outside my door. I didn’t lack the ability to make money. What I lacked was permission to have it. I had shut myself, and money with me, outside the door.

02

A turn toward Austin

I couldn’t hold on any longer. One day at noon I went to a close friend and poured out everything in my heart.

He asked me:

“If money weren’t an issue, what would you most want to do?”

I said I wanted freedom. I wanted to see the world, to live out my own worth instead of being defined by a paycheck.

He listened, then said, simply:

“Sometimes life just needs a turn.”

Just those few light words, and they moved my whole self.

I left the corporate world, and everything familiar. No next thing was waiting for me. I gave myself a gap year of doing nothing: when to get up, where to go, what to do, all as I pleased. Luckily I had saved a small cushion.

Around then I read *One Minute Millionaire*. It mentioned a woman named Cindy Cashman, who had written *Everything Men Know About Women*. It sold over a million copies and made her a millionaire, yet open the hardcover and every page inside is blank. Not a single word.

I was half-lying by a pool in Dallas, in the sun. When I read that, the thought "I want to meet her" shot through me, and I sat bolt upright.

I found out she lived in Texas too, in Austin. She didn't answer my calls or texts, only my email: Yes, I agree to meet you. Meeting her usually cost a good deal of money. She asked for none; she only told me to prepare my questions, and sent her address.

I thought through every question carefully, got in the car, and drove all the way from Dallas to Austin.

Looking back, I seem to have spent my whole life running toward what I long for. Years earlier, carrying a dream of freedom, I had left university and come to America. The drive to Austin wasn't my longest journey, but it was a rare one: I didn't think twice. On nothing but "I want to see her now," I hit the road.

03

Gentle, and wealthy too

The door opened, and a blonde woman even smaller than me, all smiles, welcomed me in.

That lakeside house was her home. The lawn, the trampoline, the woods and the big lake from the beginning were all the view from her windows. The moment I stepped inside I froze, and said to myself: I want to live in a place like this too. In that instant a seed fell into my heart. I didn't know then that it would one day bloom.

We sat down, question and answer. As we talked, she gently drew out my block around money. I told her all three of my "I don't want"s.

She listened, looked at me, and asked: Then what do you like?

I said: I'm gentle and sweet with people, but I also love elegance, and I like wise people.

She took my words and quietly added one line:

> *"You are a soft, sweet, graceful, enlightened, millionaire."*

The line came out in English. I remember the order clearly: the adjectives first, "millionaire" last.

That order was exactly the life I wanted. What I wanted was never to "be a rich person." It was to first be the me I love, and let the money follow.

She had me say the line out loud, and asked for my reason and my feeling. And so the sentence became:

I AM

"I am a soft, sweet, graceful, enlightened, millionaire. Because I'm worthy. And I feel free."

I said it out loud. She asked: How does that feel?

I said: Beautiful. Light, free. I feel taller, as if I already am.

That day I said the sentence again and again, out loud, and recorded it too.

Only later did I understand why it works. It isn't a spell that makes money appear when you chant it. Once you settle who you are, the things that person wouldn't do start to feel awkward, and little by little you drop them. What holds the old life back was never gritted-teeth willpower. It is that small feeling of "this isn't me."

04

Money isn't what changes first

After I said that sentence, the first thing to change wasn't my bank balance. It was my choices.

I gave myself a rule: do only what I love, and nothing I don't. I also stuck another line on my computer desktop: "Live in a healthy, heart-stirring, peaceful place, surrounded by the people and things I love."

The first thing I did was translate. Cindy was a well-known author and hadn't charged me, so I asked: "Is there anything I can do for you?" She thought about it and said several of her books had no Chinese editions yet. Would I translate them and get them published in China? I said: "Yes, I can!"

And so I became Cindy Cashman's translator. Later I took on *Money Is My Friend* as well; in that stretch I translated five books in a row.

In those days I spent almost all my time on things connected to that "I am": translating, reading, meeting the people I wanted to meet. Anything unrelated, I didn't touch. Only later did I learn this mattered most.

Without a job, I had time, and freedom. Strangely, back at work, however much I disliked the job, I couldn't see any other road. Once I was empty and relaxed, opportunities became audible and visible. My first business was in import and export. Later, the idea of becoming a boss, an entrepreneur, surfaced all on its own.

That "I am" came true in my life one piece at a time. I had once shut "rich people" outside my door; now I walked naturally into circles I had never dared approach, and sat down among them. It wasn't that money suddenly arrived. I first gave myself a new choice: to allow myself to stand among people like that.

None of this happened within a year. I built it day by day. A few years later I fell for a house that had just come on the market: on a lake, with a green belt of trees behind it, nothing but garden and woods outside the kitchen, living room and bedroom windows, and a creek running beside it. I bought it.

Only at that moment did I realize: wasn't this the seed that fell into my heart at Cindy's window? It had bloomed.

So I believe this. What you truly want, when you truly believe and truly act, doesn't land on you with a bang one day. It grows, slowly, one piece at a time.



05

You have your own "I am"

This sentence isn't only mine to use.

I have a partner who used to insist he wasn't worth it. When people offered him money, he couldn't take it; it made him squirm. Then one day he changed his words and told himself: I'm worthy. Just those two words, and everything turned out differently.

You don't have to become someone first. Just say your "I am" to yourself. Once it's said, you have already claimed yourself. The rest is growing into it.

On this road I also met Teacher Ma Jihong, a mind-body-spirit mentor. Since the very first Play and Prosper book, I have invited her to every opening and closing camp to empower our authors. She is one of my great benefactors; over the years she has helped more people than anyone can count. Not long ago, at an opening camp, she said something I agreed with the moment I heard it:

> **Change your identity, and your life will shift.**
>
> — Ma Jihong

Let that sink in. All of us here are doing exactly this: changing one "I am," and letting life move in that direction.

Take me. I am someone who thinks in English. I am a traveler on the way to a hundred countries. I am a citizen of the Earth. Each time I say an "I am," my heart grows a little bigger, big enough to see the whole planet.

06

Thirty-six people, thirty-six ways to live

And this “I am” was never mine alone. This book has thirty-six authors: thirty-six ways to live, thirty-six voices.

Some are in China, some overseas. Some are still on the road, some have arrived. Some are raising children, some are raising students. Some want to live more freely, some want to pass on what they know.

But read them one by one and you will find they all write about the same thing: one day, they changed an “I am.” Some went from “I’m just a worker” to “I’m a creator.” Some from “I don’t deserve it” to “I’m worthy.” Some from “I’ll go on stage when I’m ready” to “I’m going on stage now.” At the moment of that change, their lives shifted.

At some point, each of them found their own way of living again, and each was willing, in this AI era, to write that road down, so those still hesitating can take a few fewer wrong turns.

AI can copy methods, copy copywriting, copy efficiency. The one thing it cannot copy is your “I am.” The stronger AI becomes, the more “only you can live this way” is worth.

I don’t want you to read them as role models. Role models make people more anxious: why can they do it and I can’t? Stories don’t. A good story lets you run into yourself inside someone else’s life.

Maybe right now you can’t yet say your own “I am.” I understand. The me who first said “I am” out loud in that lakeside living room,

for a long time before that, couldn't even say what she wanted. I could only sit in a cubicle, staring at a gray sky.

From not being able to say it to saying it out loud, the method I used comes down to a few steps:

METHOD

Three steps to make your "I am" real

01 **Claim it** *I am*

Say three sentences in one breath: "I am" to claim the identity, "because" to give it a reason, and "I feel" to anchor the right feeling in your body. Think of something that makes you stretch out and lose track of time when you do it. That feeling is the one.

02 **Say it** *Out loud*

Don't say it silently. Say it out loud, every day.

03 **Live it** *Say so, do so*

Every day, set aside time that belongs only to it, and do it again and again. Day after day, all the way.

Claim it · Say it · Live it: say "I am," then live it.

Three sentences, just words. Why would they work? Because they get around the two toughest opponents: willpower and the subconscious. With willpower, you don't have to grit your teeth; you settle

"who I am" first, and behavior follows. With the subconscious, you don't attack head-on. A thought in your head you can always argue with, but once the words leave your mouth and you hear them, the subconscious takes what you keep saying as true, and quietly carries you toward that "I am."

Step three, live it, is the unity of knowing and doing. People say knowing is easy and doing is hard. But the hard part was always going against yourself, and the first two steps have already taken that apart: your identity pulls from the front, your voice pushes from behind. Once it flows, doing is no longer a grind. It moves on its own.

Which way to go comes down to one question: does this match my "I feel"? If it does, do it. If not, let it go. Ask that all day, and the path clears by itself.

Just don't misunderstand. The moment you say it, you will feel "I already am," but that is the beginning, not the finish. It was so for me. Claiming it and saying it began that afternoon at Cindy's. What truly turned me into another person were the years after, giving my time, day after day, to what that "I am" should do. Give more, and it comes faster; give less, and it still comes, more slowly. The only thing to fear is stopping.

You don't have to copy my three steps. In this book, some people changed through a decision, some through a long journey, some through a single sentence. The methods differ, but peel them back and they are the same thing: change one "I am," then live it.

In the end, this book and these thirty-six ways of living want to ask you just one thing:

How do you want the world to remember you?

You don't have to answer beautifully right now. If you can't say it yet, start with this:

I'm worthy.

我值得。

As for my answer: I am a free person. I came into this world free; I follow the Way, I am complete in myself, and I serve others.

Right now I am writing these words on my own farm. Blue sky outside the window; cattle on the grass, heads down, grazing.



You have your own “I am” too. Maybe it has no shape yet. That’s fine. Say it first, then fill it in, slowly, with your days.

Saying it is the beginning. Living it, day by day:

you are simply you.

Become you.

Lily

On my farm in Dallas

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Lily

01 Business restructuring coach for founder-led brands

02 Producer & translator of 20+ bestsellers

03 Co-founder, Play and Prosper

AI master's graduate in the US, producer and translator of 20+ best-selling books, creator of 100+ AI agents. Lily helps personal brands, seasoned founders and business owners restructure for the AI era: turning abilities into assets and experience into products. She leads a hundred authors across eight time zones to write books together, using clear sys-ness without the grind. Play and prosper.

Scan to connect with Lily

Get a book straight from the author



EXCERPTED FROM

Play and Prosper: Personal Branding in the AI Era

Edited by Li Haifeng, Lily & Muxiao • Taihai Publishing House

playandprosper.com